

Module 6: Refugees, Asylum, and Forced Displacement

Graduate Research Project

Does Protection Protect? A Comparative Study of Asylum System Performance

Overview

A comparative policy analysis of asylum system effectiveness across two or three jurisdictions, using recognition rates, processing times, appeals outcomes, and reception conditions.

Aligned learning outcomes

- Critically assess protection system limitations (Grad 1)
- Analyze policy implications (Grad 2)

Sample research questions

- Why do recognition rates for the same nationality vary dramatically across (and within) countries?
- What do processing backlogs and appeal reversal rates reveal about system quality?
- Which reforms show credible evidence of improving both fairness and efficiency?

Methods

Comparative case design using EUAA, UNHCR, TRAC, and national statistics plus secondary literature. Standardize metrics across jurisdictions and address data comparability problems explicitly.

IRB / research ethics

Not required for statistical/documentary design; required if adding practitioner interviews.

Deliverables

- 4,500-word comparative policy critique
- Comparative metrics dashboard (table or chart set)
- One-page reform brief

Grading rubric

Each criterion is scored at one of four levels, then weighted as shown. The overall grade is the weighted combination of criterion scores. Instructors may adapt weights and descriptors to local requirements.

Criterion (weight)	Exemplary (A)	Proficient (B)	Developing (C)	Beginning (D–F)
Comparability rigor — honest handling of messy data 30%	Method is rigorous and transparent: comparability rigor — honest handling of messy data is fully documented, choices are justified, limitations are stated, and another student could replicate the work from what is written.	Method is sound: comparability rigor — honest handling of messy data is documented and mostly justified, with limitations acknowledged; small gaps would not change the findings.	Method is partial: comparability rigor — honest handling of messy data is described but under-documented or inconsistently applied, leaving findings plausible but not checkable.	Method is absent or unsound: comparability rigor — honest handling of messy data is missing, undocumented, or applied so loosely that the findings cannot be trusted.
Depth of institutional analysis 30%	Analysis is genuinely insightful: depth of institutional analysis goes beyond summary to produce non-obvious, well-defended conclusions; concepts are applied accurately, complexity is preserved, and counterpoints are engaged seriously.	Analysis is competent: depth of institutional analysis is achieved with clear reasoning and accurate use of course concepts, though conclusions stay near the expected.	Analysis is thin: depth of institutional analysis is attempted but leans on summary or assertion; concepts are named more than used, and complications are avoided.	Analysis is absent: depth of institutional analysis is not achieved; the work describes without analyzing or draws conclusions its own material does not support.
Quality of evidence-based reform proposals 25%	Evidence and accuracy are exemplary: quality of evidence-based reform proposals is met with high-quality, correctly cited sources for every substantive claim; terms, facts, and frameworks are used precisely.	Evidence and accuracy are solid: quality of evidence-based reform proposals is met for nearly all claims, with only minor sourcing gaps or imprecisions that do not affect conclusions.	Evidence and accuracy are uneven: quality of evidence-based reform proposals is partly met — some claims lack support, sources are thin or misread, or terms are used loosely in ways that weaken conclusions.	Evidence and accuracy are deficient: quality of evidence-based reform proposals is not met; key claims are unsupported or wrong, and errors undermine the work's conclusions.

Criterion (weight)	Exemplary (A)	Proficient (B)	Developing (C)	Beginning (D–F)
Presentation of the metrics 15%	Communication is publication-ready: presentation of the metrics is achieved with precise, well-organized prose, correct citation, and figures or formats that make the argument easier to grasp.	Communication is clear and professional: presentation of the metrics is achieved with minor lapses in polish, organization, or citation that never obscure meaning.	Communication is understandable but rough: presentation of the metrics is only partly achieved — disorganization, citation errors, or unclear figures make the reader work to follow the argument.	Communication impedes the work: presentation of the metrics is not achieved; errors, disorganization, or missing citations obscure the substance.